date from Ayodhya. Pandey was the SP face who made the scandal public—so it keeps activated that entire line of attack. As a Brahmin, he doubles the value. In Etawah, meanwile, Akhilesh has built—for over Rs 50 crore—the Kedareshwar Mahadev Temple. Krishna symbolism, too, has helped own a Yadava lineage.

BRAHMIN NUMEROLOGY

Its Brahmin outreach has a clear electoral calculation. The BSP's enfeeblement saw goodish portions of the Dalit vote drift towards the SP in the 2024 general election, aided by the company it kept with the Congress. But other social blocs still stood at a sullen distance. Among them were the Brahmins. At 8-12 per cent of the electorate, spread across UP, they are a meaningful part of the political spectrum. A minor swing among this cohort can decide many closely fought seats. Their massive presence in the opinion classes lends another vital dimension to this.

The Brahmins have not always voted as a single bloc. The macro trend, since the 1990s, saw them largely shed their old Congress loyalties to find a conducive habitat in saffron. It wasn't without strains—talk of Thakur domination in UP of late being especially chafing. After the BSP demonstrated their capacity for electoral mobility in 2007, their bivalence has at times been on display in the past decade. Still, when the SP-BSP-Congress triad contested tactically, outside of alliances, it was the Congress that put up Brahmin faces to cut BJP votes. The assumption: they would remain allergic to the SP.

The root of their TINA mindset was social: the SP was an arrant symbol—along with the BSP—of the forces that had upset the old order. Before the arrival of Mulayam Singh Yadav in 1989, Brahmins were first among equals, with six chief ministers ruling for nearly half of the years since 1950. As the political force that had ended their run, keeping their distance from the SP even when disenchanted with the ruling order had become a call of duty, a reflex behaviour. It's this settled antipathy that Akhilesh seeks to dissolve.

With the BJP's forward-caste coalition under pressure, the SP wishes to be the destination of all migrating votes. But it's premature to think of it as a done deal. Attacking the BJP on governance while seeking to reassure Hindu voters on faith seems logical. But part of the savarna disquiet with the BJP is over reservations—seeing that flowing to a Mandal party as 'revenge vote' is counterintuitive. There is also a delicate balance here. The original PDA—Yadavs, Muslims, sections of the wider *bahujan*—forms its principal support base. Can the SP persuade Brahmins to come on board without seeming to dilute that? ■

Takeaways

- **SP woos a key saffron vote: the Brahmins, who are 8-12% of UP's electorate. Hindu imagery to melt old animus**
- **SP face Pawan Pandey, who first publicised the Ram temple theft allegations, made candidate from Ayodhya**
- **This reprises Mayawati's 2007 experiment to expand BSP base. But can SP pull off the balancing act?**

▶ MAHARASHTRA

The Never Ending Pawar Saga

Both NCP factions are on the cusp of definitive change, but the plot is full of twists and turns

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

THE ORIGINAL WAS ITSELF THE CHILD OF A SPLIT. The Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) was formed when Sharad Pawar branched off from the parent Congress, not for the first time, so as to better nurture his ambitions in the fragmenting political landscape of the late 1990s. It stands to logic that the amoeba-like gene that birthed it would not vanish. In 2023, his nephew Ajit Pawar proved the biological capacity to split as well as shift form was alive and well, forking away towards the ruling Bharatiya

IN HIS MEMORY Deputy CM Sunetra Pawar and son Parth, NCP national general secretary

